

Joint lease protection guide, documentation strategies, exit planning — Action Checklist

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CALCULATE YOUR FINANCIAL EXPOSURE

- ☐ **Calculate Your Financial Exposure, Item 1:** Determine your exact liability by adding your roommate's portion plus accumulated late fees as specified in your lease to get your real exposure number.
- ☐ **Calculate Your Financial Exposure, Item 2:** Create a liability worksheet listing your monthly rent, your roommate's share, your state's maximum late fee, how many days past due the payment is, and your lease's grace period terms.
- ☐ **Calculate Your Financial Exposure, Item 3:** Review your lease to identify grace period terms, state-mandated late fee caps, and your joint and several liability clause that makes you responsible for the full amount owed.
- ☐ **Calculate Your Financial Exposure, Item 4:** Know your state's landlord mitigation requirement so you understand that your landlord cannot let the debt accumulate indefinitely without attempting to re-rent the unit.

DOCUMENT YOUR RESPONSIBLE BEHAVIOR

- ☐ **Document Your Responsible Behavior, Item 1:** Keep screenshots of every payment you made with timestamps showing you paid your portion on time throughout your tenancy to demonstrate your reliability as the responsible tenant.
- ☐ **Document Your Responsible Behavior, Item 2:** Save all text messages and emails where you requested payment from your roommate, including dates and specific amounts requested, to prove you tried to resolve the shortfall directly.
- ☐ **Document Your Responsible Behavior, Item 3:** Keep copies of every landlord notice you receive, your written responses to them, and any written commitments your landlord makes regarding your separate liability from your roommate.
- ☐ **Document Your Responsible Behavior, Item 4:** Create a detailed timeline documenting every rent payment date, when you first noticed the shortfall, every attempt to contact your roommate, and all landlord communications about the situation.

EXECUTE YOUR EXIT STRATEGY

- ☐ **Execute Your Exit Strategy, Item 1:** Send your landlord a formal written letter stating you are the responsible tenant who paid your share on time, and request separation from your roommate's lease obligation before eviction proceedings begin.
 - ☐ **Execute Your Exit Strategy, Item 2:** Ask your landlord whether you can sign a new individual lease or be released from the current joint lease so your rental history remains intact for future applications.
 - ☐ **Execute Your Exit Strategy, Item 3:** Document the condition of your unit with photos and videos before you leave, and request a formal walkthrough inspection with your landlord to protect your security deposit.
 - ☐ **Execute Your Exit Strategy, Item 4:** Prepare a professional explanation for your next rental application that frames this situation as handling a difficult circumstance responsibly through documentation and prompt landlord notification.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.